

Demand-side vs supply-side pornography research and the consumer–worker outcomes gap

Executive summary

Pornography research is often split—implicitly or explicitly—between demand-side work (studying viewers/consumers and downstream social, psychological, and behavioral outcomes) and supply-side work (studying performers/creators, production conditions, platform governance, occupational health, safety, labor rights, and economic precarity). Over the last decade, the empirical “center of gravity” of the field has remained demand-heavy: the largest, most frequently cited datasets tend to be consumer surveys, longitudinal youth/adult cohorts, experiments, and meta-analyses addressing outcomes such as sexual aggression, sexual risk behaviors, sexual functioning, relationship well-being, and “problematic pornography use” (PPU).

Supply-side studies have expanded—especially with the rise of platform-mediated adult content creation (e.g., subscription platforms, gig-economy logics, algorithmic governance)—but they remain comparatively smaller-scale, more qualitative, more legally/ethically constrained, and more directly shaped by stigma and platform policies. This has produced an enduring consumer–worker outcomes gap: evidence and policy arguments about pornography frequently rest on consumer-facing outcomes, while worker-facing outcomes (workplace hazards, consent/contracting realities, health protocols, harassment/doxxing, deplatforming and payment exclusion, and stigma-driven barriers to labor protections) are less systematically measured and less often treated as primary endpoints.

A second, related gap is epistemic: stigma and “dirty work” dynamics shape which questions are asked, whose testimony is treated as credible, which sites are safe to study, and which methods survive IRB scrutiny. Work on sex-industry stigma and epistemic injustice argues that marginalized workers can be excluded not only socially but as legitimate knowers of their own occupational risks—contributing to mismatched regulations and narrow evidence bases.

Methodologically and ethically, the field faces unusually strong constraints: recruitment is hindered by high privacy risks, fear of outing, criminalization spillovers, platform moderation/deplatforming, and payment processor exclusions; consent and confidentiality are hard to guarantee in digital environments; and researchers themselves may face harassment, reputational risk, or institutional resistance. Existing guidance for internet research ethics and sensitive-topic work emphasizes contextual, harm-minimizing approaches—but translating general guidance into pornography-specific practice remains uneven.

The report concludes that reducing the demand–supply gap requires (a) re-centering worker outcomes as first-class research endpoints, (b) measurement and sampling innovations capable of reaching workers safely, (c) participatory/collaborative designs that treat performers/creators as knowledge-producers, not merely subjects, and (d) IRB and institutional reforms tailored to digital sexual-content contexts, including stronger confidentiality tooling (e.g., Certificates of Confidentiality where applicable), and clearer standards for online recruitment and risk mitigation.

Conceptual foundations and definitions

“Demand-side” and “supply-side” are not standard disciplinary labels in pornography research, but they are analytically useful for clarifying what populations and outcomes are centered.

Demand-side pornography research (consumer-centered) focuses on viewers/users (or partners of viewers) and investigates outcomes such as:

sexual attitudes and scripts, sexual functioning, relationship satisfaction, and well-being;
sexual risk behavior and developmental trajectories (especially for adolescents/young adults);
associations with violence, sexual aggression, coercion-related beliefs, or related behaviors
(often contested and heterogeneous across designs);

“problematic pornography use” (PPU) conceptualization, prevalence, measurement quality, and clinical correlates.

Supply-side pornography research (producer/worker-centered) focuses on the labor and production side and typically investigates:

occupational health and safety (OHS), testing regimes, STI prevention practices, injury/health burdens, and safety governance;

digital harms (outing, doxxing, stalking, content leakage, “capping,” harassment), platform precariousness and censorship, and safety practices;

labor rights, employment classification, regulatory enforcement, and the role of stigma in blocking protections;

platform governance and political economy (algorithmic curation, datafication, payment processor constraints, and AI-generated pornography governance).

Key concept map

Dirty work and occupational taint. “Dirty work” theory in organizational sociology characterizes certain jobs as tainted (physically, socially, or morally), producing stigma and identity-management pressures for workers; pornography labor and adjacent sex-industry work are widely analyzed through this lens.

Stigma. Classic stigma theory (e.g., Erving Goffman’s account of “spoiled identity”) has been extended in contemporary stigma research to emphasize multi-level mechanisms (structural, institutional, interactional) that shape opportunities, health, and voice.

Knowledge production and STS. Science and Technology Studies highlights that knowledge is produced within institutions, incentives, infrastructures, and power relations. In pornography research, “datafication” and platform-produced “insights” can reshape what counts as evidence about sexuality—sometimes presenting corporate analytics as objective social science despite opaque methods and ideological framing.

Epistemic injustice. Miranda Fricker’s framework distinguishes testimonial injustice (discounting someone’s credibility) and hermeneutical injustice (lacking shared interpretive resources to

make experiences legible). Recent pornography-OHS scholarship explicitly argues that performer knowledge can be institutionally discounted, distorting workplace safety policy.

Sexuality research and “sex exceptionalism.” Sexuality is frequently treated as an exceptional domain requiring heightened gatekeeping, moral scrutiny, or background assumptions about vulnerability and harm; this can shape IRB review, measurement choices, and public reception of findings. In porn-related OHS debates, scholars argue that “sex exceptionalism” can erase worker-centered understandings of risk and safety by framing porn as *sui generis* rather than as labor with standard workplace hazards and governance needs.

State of the literature in the last decade

The most relevant “demand vs supply” gap is not only topical but structural: demand-side studies more often benefit from high-reach recruitment pipelines (schools, population panels, online panels), standardized survey tools, and “socially legible” outcome variables; supply-side studies more often require trust-based access, specialized safeguards, and navigation of platform and institutional barriers.

Demand-side emphases and their limits

Longitudinal youth/young-adult exposure and sexual risk outcomes. A prominent strand examines adolescent exposure to sexually explicit media and later sexual risk behaviors. For example, a Taiwan-based longitudinal study using instrumental-variable estimation reported associations between early exposure and later risky sexual behaviors (e.g., earlier sexual debut, unsafe sex, more partners), while also noting measurement limits (e.g., exposure measures not capturing frequency or dynamic change).

More recent synthesis work underscores heterogeneous longitudinal findings and cautions against simple “porn → harm” causal narratives without attention to moderators, measurement, and baseline vulnerabilities.

Pornography and violence/aggression debates. A large, politically salient evidence stream assesses whether pornography use is associated with sexual aggression or related attitudes/behaviors. A major meta-analysis of general-population studies reported a positive association between pornography consumption and actual acts of sexual aggression, while also testing moderators and emphasizing ongoing debate.

Yet broader systematic review work finds substantial heterogeneity in how both “pornography use” and “violence” are conceptualized, and mixed results across outcomes such as intimate partner sexual coercion, rape myths, and causality claims.

Problematic pornography use and measurement instability. A defining feature of the last decade is the rapid expansion of PPU research and screening tools. Cross-national measurement validation efforts suggest instruments can be used across languages and demographic groups, but also indicate that only a subset of those who screen positive seek treatment or want to but do not, implying barriers beyond prevalence.

At the same time, a COSMIN-based measurement review concludes validated outcome measures are still insufficient across key psychometric domains (including content validity and responsiveness), limiting cross-study comparability and complicating inference about prevalence and change over time.

Population trends and context dependence. Large-scale, nationally representative longitudinal evidence during COVID-era conditions shows that pornography use did not uniformly increase and that trends can move downward, challenging popular assumptions that crises inevitably produce sustained consumption spikes.

Systematic reviews of young people's internet pornography use increasingly stress mixed associations across multiple domains of "psychosexual well-being," and critique a historical bias toward negative framings and male-centered samples.

Supply-side emphases and their limits

Occupational health and safety in production contexts. Empirical work with adult film performers documents high-frequency STI screening and persistent STI detection over long periods, alongside reports of condomless sex as normative in some production contexts.

Public health incident reporting underscores that reliance on testing alone is insufficient for preventing HIV transmission in production settings and recommends layered prevention (e.g., condom use, frequent testing, PrEP).

A key limitation is that many OHS studies rely on convenience samples, clinic/testing records, or industry-linked access, and may not capture the full heterogeneity of performers (including those excluded from mainstream testing regimes or working in platform-mediated solo/peer-to-peer production).

Labor rights enforcement under platformization. Recent socio-legal work argues that occupational health and safety protections can apply even when platforms classify creators as self-employed, and that stigma is a major driver of "non-enforcement" because porn work is relegated to social margins and treated as a lawless zone.

Parallel theoretical work on occupational health and epistemic injustice argues that worker participation is broadly recognized as essential in OHS governance, but adult film workers may be structurally excluded as credible knowers—producing policy that is poorly fitted to lived working conditions.

Digital threats, safety practices, and platform precarity. Security and social-media research with subscription-platform creators documents a threat landscape that includes toxic content and content leakage, but also platform-specific risks (shadowbanning, censorship, deplatforming) that drive proactive safety practices and diversification across platforms.

Broader qualitative work across sex workers, LGBTQ+ activists, and sex educators theorizes “hyper(in)visibility” on platforms: simultaneous public scrutiny and algorithmic erasure, involving outing/doxxing and strategic invisibility tactics.

Platform governance, datafication, and AI pornography. STS research argues that “porn insights” sites transform massive clickstream data into culturally authoritative “facts” about sexuality while remaining opaque about data generation and interpretation; such outputs can become inputs to journalism and scholarship even when they primarily advance corporate taxonomies and ideological “dataism.”

In parallel, research on AI-generated pornography platforms shows heterogeneous governance regimes in content prohibitions, moderation, liability allocation, IP rules, and privacy policies—positioning platforms as arbiters of “legitimate sexuality,” while shaping labor exploitation risks and commodifying intimate data.

Comparative table of key studies

The table below highlights a curated set of high-relevance studies and reports (prioritizing the last decade), chosen to represent core demand-side and supply-side traditions, plus bridge/STS work. “Focus” indicates whether the study primarily centers consumer outcomes (demand), worker/producer outcomes (supply), or explicitly addresses both.

Study (year)	Primary field(s)	Focus	Aims	Methods	Sample	Main findings
(high-level)	Key limitations / cautions					
Pornography use and violence: systematic review (last 20 years) (2024)						
Public health / violence research		Demand		Synthesize evidence on pornography use–violence associations		
		Systematic review		59 studies (review corpus)		Reports heterogeneous results across constructs and outcomes; causality often unclear; emphasizes conceptual heterogeneity as a main limitation
				Review depends on primary-study quality;		construct definitions vary substantially
Porn consumption & actual sexual aggression: meta-analysis (2016)						
Communication / psychology		Demand		Estimate association between pornography consumption and acts of sexual aggression, test moderators		
(meta-analytic corpus)				Meta-analysis	22 studies	
				Finds pornography consumption positively associated with sexual aggression; explores moderators (e.g., age, national context)		Correlational primary studies dominate; residual confounding and measurement heterogeneity remain
Adolescents, pornography use & PPU: rapid longitudinal review (2025)						
Child/adolescent psychiatry		Demand		Synthesize longitudinal evidence in adolescents across outcomes		
		Rapid systematic review		44 longitudinal studies		Reports mixed/heterogeneous longitudinal associations across outcomes, with some null long-term relationships depending on outcome
				Rapid-review streamlining; publication bias and measurement variance noted		
Young people’s internet porn use & psychosexual well-being (2025)						
Sexual health / psychology		Demand		Review prevalence, motivations, content types, and associations with psychosexual well-being		
		Systematic review (quantitative evidence synthesis)				

27 studies; 30,023 participants Concludes most young people report use; highlights gender differences; critiques historical focus on negative framings and male overrepresentation
Quality varies; geographic and measurement limits; narrative synthesis constraints
SEM exposure in early adolescence → risky sex in adulthood (2020)

Public health / sociology Demand Estimate relation of adolescent SEM exposure to later risky sexual behavior Longitudinal cohort + IV estimation Taiwan Youth Project cohort
SEM exposure associated with earlier sexual debut, unsafe sex, multiple partners; acknowledges measurement limitations Exposure measured early and relatively coarsely; cultural specificity; instrument validity assumptions matter

Pandemic: pornography use before & during COVID in representative US sample (2021/2022)
Psychology / social science Demand Track changes in pornography use and “problematic use” during pandemic Longitudinal, nationally representative panel US adults (panel) Use trended downward overall; only a minority reported increases early in pandemic and returned toward baseline Pandemic context may not generalize; self-report and measurement choices constrain inference

PPU across countries, genders, orientations (International Sex Survey) (2024)
Addiction / cross-cultural psychometrics Demand Validate PPU screening tools across languages and demographics Multinational survey + measurement validation
Multi-country, multi-language sample Supports cross-language tool validity; indicates treatment seeking among PPU+ is relatively low; some report wanting but not accessing treatment
Screening ≠ clinical diagnosis; cultural response patterns; access-to-care measures indirect
PPU outcome measures COSMIN review (2026)

Clinical psychology / measurement science Demand Evaluate psychometric quality of PPU outcome measures COSMIN systematic review 47 studies; 24 instruments No instrument sufficient across all domains; content validity and responsiveness often missing
Measurement conclusions depend on reporting quality; rapidly evolving instrument landscape
Chlamydia/gonorrhea prevalence & behaviors among adult film performers (2017)

STI epidemiology Supply Describe behaviors and estimate STI prevalence among performers Observational study Adult film performers (clinical/sample details in PubMed record) Reports prevalence patterns and transmission behaviors relevant to OHS Sampling and representativeness; linkage to production contexts may be partial

UK adult film performers: STI testing patterns & outcomes (1996–2015 data) (2019/2020)
Sexual health Supply Describe STI testing frequency/outcomes among UK performers
Record-based observational analysis 100 performers; long time-span Reports frequent screening (~every 3 weeks) and STI occurrence; reports condomless sex as high
Historical period; limited to those in regular screening systems

State public health report on occupational HIV transmission in adult entertainment (2015)
Public health / occupational health Supply Summarize an on-set HIV transmission investigation and prevention points Official health alert/report Case-based public health reporting Emphasizes that testing alone is insufficient; recommends condoms, frequent testing, and considering PrEP Not peer-reviewed; limited detail; nonetheless influential for layered prevention framing

Stigma inhibits enforcement of health & safety regulation for adult content creators (2024/2025)

Law / sociology Supply Explain why OHS protections are poorly enforced on porn platforms Socio-legal + interviews 9 UK-based adult content creators Argues stigma drives non-enforcement; creators self-regulate risk at own cost; platforms should have obligations for training/PPE Small sample; UK legal context; focuses on platform-mediated creators rather than all production models

Epistemic injustice and occupational health in porn production (2025)

STS / public health policy Supply Analyze how performer knowledge is excluded in OHS policy Document analysis + theory Policy/meeting documents (California OHS context) Argues performer exclusion is epistemic injustice; worker participation is central to effective OHS; porn treated as exceptional Case-focused; depends on available documentation and interpretive analysis

Digital threats & safety practices of subscription-platform creators (2024)

Security / HCI Supply Identify threats and protective practices for creators producing intimate content Qualitative interviews 43 creators Finds platform precarity/censorship and content leakage are central threats; participants emphasize proactive safety practices Qualitative scope; platform/user demographics limit generalization

Strategic invisibility under hyper(in)visibility (2024)

Platform studies Supply Explain risk management among marginalized sexual content creators 27 interviews Sex workers, LGBTQ+ activists, sex educators Describes tactics for strategic invisibility amid surveillance, harassment, outing, doxxing Not porn-only; combines related populations; still crucial for platform risk mechanisms

Big data on “porn insights” and sexual culture (2025)

STS / critical data studies Demand-side evidence critique (bridge) Analyze ideological role of platform analytics as sexual knowledge Thematic analysis of platform posts + media reception Sample of “insights” posts + media coverage Argues “insights” framed as definitive facts despite opacity; constructs taxonomies that shape sexual culture and knowledge Not a consumer-outcome study; focuses on knowledge production rather than individual-level effects

Governance of AI-generated pornography platforms (2026)

Platform governance / STS Supply-side infrastructure (bridge) Map governance materials across AI porn platforms Content analysis Governance materials from 98 platforms Shows heterogeneous regimes; highlights liability allocation, privacy, content prohibitions; platforms arbitrate legitimate sexuality and extract value Governance documents ≠ enacted practice; rapid policy change likely

Methods, ethics, and IRB barriers specific to pornography research

Pornography research inherits many “sensitive topic” constraints typical of sexuality research, but also has pornography-specific features—especially platform governance and reputational/occupational stigma—that amplify risks to participants and researchers.

Recruitment and sampling barriers

Worker/producer recruitment is structurally harder than consumer recruitment. Demand-side studies can often recruit through schools, general population panels, clinics, or online panels. Supply-side recruitment typically requires trusted gatekeepers, snowball sampling, or affiliation

with worker organizations; even then, the perceived risk of outing or professional consequences can depress participation. In a UK study of adult content creators, recruitment relied on sex worker organizations and snowballing via social platforms.

Platform policies and deplatforming shape who can be reached and how. Mainstream platforms enforce sexual content restrictions and recommendation limits that affect where adult creators can advertise or communicate. For instance, Instagram's sensitive content controls and nudity/sexual content removals constrain visibility and may suppress recruitment posts or community-building.

TikTok similarly emphasizes strict policies on nudity/sexual activity and has described strengthened enforcement on sexually suggestive content—affecting both creator livelihoods and researchers' ability to recruit in-platform.

On X, adult content visibility is framed through “sensitive media” labeling and age restrictions, which shapes discoverability and can change what recruitment content is permitted or visible.

Empirically, sex workers have documented systematic deplatforming in the wake of legal and policy shifts (including post-FOSTA/SESTA dynamics), which can push workers into riskier conditions and make stable sampling frames brittle.

Payment infrastructure is a research barrier, not only an industry barrier. Worker-facing recruitment often requires fair compensation for time, but institutional anxiety about “undue inducement” can collide with participants' labor framing. Recent methodological ethics scholarship argues for treating participation as labor and for context-sensitive payment rationale, especially with marginalized workers.

Consent, confidentiality, and harm

Confidentiality is unusually high-stakes. Pornography work is widely stigmatized; being identified can trigger job loss, family conflict, harassment, doxxing, and violence. Digital threats research with subscription-platform creators highlights risks of outing, doxxing, stalking, and intimate content leakage that can be “permanent” once online.

Consent is complicated by online context and by “content leakage” hazards. Internet research ethics guidance emphasizes context: “public” availability of online content does not automatically erase privacy expectations or risks, and researchers should assess vulnerability, identifiability, and downstream harms.

Pornography research often intersects with communities that already experience surveillance and harassment; the AoIR guidelines explicitly stress ethical pluralism, harm minimization, and situational judgment rather than checkbox compliance, including operational security considerations.

Risk of retraumatization and adverse consequences. Some supply-side samples (e.g., clinical/support-group recruited women featured in video-based pornography) report high levels of prior sexual violence and severe psychopathology, illustrating a population where careful trauma-informed protocols and referral pathways are essential.

At the same time, worker-led guidance warns that poorly designed sex-work-related research can worsen stigma, enable discriminatory policing, or otherwise harm dignity and human rights, even when researchers have good intentions.

Institutional/IRB barriers and available guidance

Institutional and IRB resistance to “sex” research is itself documented. Field-based sex work research accounts describe how ethical protocols, gatekeepers, and institutional pressures shape access, rapport, and researcher safety—highlighting that the ethics process is not neutral infrastructure but a site where stigma can be reproduced.

Internet research guidance relevant to pornography research includes:

Secretary’s Advisory Committee on Human Research Protections guidance on internet research emphasizes that human subjects regulations and privacy expectations require contextual analysis rather than simple “public = exempt” reasoning.

Association of Internet Researchers Ethics 3.0 highlights stage-based decision-making, situational ethics, risk minimization, and operational security, explicitly addressing contemporary pressures that can include institutional and political risk to researchers.

National Institutes of Health policy explains that Certificates of Confidentiality can be automatic for some NIH-funded research and can be requested for other projects within NIH’s mission, supporting protections against compelled disclosure of identifiable sensitive information.

University-level IRB tools often operationalize “public vs private online spaces” distinctions for recruitment and observation, underscoring that identifiability and expectation of privacy are central.

Pornography-specific IRB pressure points. Across the above guidance and the sex-work research literature, recurring IRB concerns in pornography-adjacent studies include: verification that participants are adults; managing disclosure of illegal activity (especially any risk of minors or non-consensual content); preventing collection of unnecessary identifiers; secure storage; managing mandated reporting triggers; and minimizing reputational harms that IRBs may treat as “non-physical” but still severe.

Stigma, dirty work, and knowledge production

The demand–supply gap is not merely an imbalance of topics; it is produced through stigma-mediated mechanisms that shape what can be known, who is heard, and which harms are legible.

How stigma and dirty-work dynamics shape the evidence base

Stigma changes what gets measured. Demand-side research often operationalizes pornography in terms that map onto social anxieties—risk, addiction, violence, dysfunction—because these

constructs are fundable, IRB-legible, and policy-salient. Measurement scholarship increasingly warns that even within PPU research, definitions and instruments proliferate without full validation, making it easier to “count” problematic use than to reliably compare it across settings.

Stigma changes whose outcomes are treated as primary. Supply-side outcomes such as labor rights enforcement, occupational training, and platform-provided protective equipment are often treated as “industry issues,” not central public health endpoints. Yet recent socio-legal work argues that platforms’ classification strategies and stigma-driven non-enforcement shift safety burdens onto workers (self-regulation, paying for prevention privately), creating predictable inequities in health and safety outcomes.

Stigma changes research governance. Sex work research ethics scholarship documents that ethics review processes can disempower community stakeholders and prioritize academic expertise over lived expertise, potentially increasing risk to participants and undermining collaborative safety design.

Epistemic injustice as a mechanism of the demand–supply gap

A core claim in recent supply-side scholarship is that adult industry workers may be treated as non-credible or non-authoritative about workplace hazards. This produces epistemic injustice: when performers’ testimony is discounted, OHS policy may default to outsider assumptions about risk. The result can be regulatory approaches that emphasize symbolic risk control (or moral messaging) rather than worker-defined hazard control, especially when porn is treated as “exceptional.”

A key counterpoint embedded in occupational health doctrine is that worker participation improves safety programs because workers “often know the most” about job hazards; OHS bodies and many legal frameworks support worker representation as a core principle. The pornography-OHS literature argues the tension arises when that general principle collides with stigma-driven disbelief that porn workers can be responsible knowledge producers.

Platform datafication as demand-side knowledge dominance

Demand-side “knowledge” about pornography is increasingly produced not only by surveys but by platform analytics and data visualizations that circulate as quasi-official indicators of sexual culture. Critical data studies argue this can crowd out slower, contextual, qualitative knowledge and can naturalize corporate taxonomies (including heteronormative or derogatory category structures) as if they were neutral descriptors of desire.

Conceptual diagram of relationships

Structural stigma & moral politics

Institutional constraints: funding, IRB risk framing

Platform governance: moderation, deplatforming, payment exclusion

Method effects: who can be sampled; what can be asked

Knowledge production bias: consumer-centric measures dominate

Policy focus: restrict demand / individual pathology models

Underproduction of worker-centered evidence

Consumer outcomes prioritized in debate

Worker outcomes undermeasured and underprotected

Show code

Practical implications and recommendations

Bridging demand- and supply-side outcomes is feasible, but it requires treating pornography research as simultaneously (a) sexuality research, (b) labor/occupational health research, and (c) platform governance research.

Implications for researchers

Rebalancing the field requires deliberately shifting from “porn users” as the default unit of analysis to multi-actor systems (consumers, creators/performers, producers/platforms, payment/advertising infrastructure, regulators), with explicit modeling of how demand signals and platform curation affect worker conditions. Platform-threat and OHS studies show that worker harms often arise from structural constraints (platform precarity, stigma, non-enforcement) rather than only from individual behavior.

Concrete researcher-facing recommendations:

Pre-register “worker outcomes” as primary endpoints when studying pornography ecosystems (e.g., exposure to harassment, deplatforming events, income volatility, access to healthcare/testing, safety training access), rather than treating them as qualitative context. Use participatory or sex worker-led/partnered methods where possible. Worker-led guidance emphasizes that extractive designs can amplify stigma and risk; collaborative designs can improve safety and validity.

Triangulate data sources to avoid single-infrastructure bias (e.g., combine interviews with platform policy audits and—where ethical—aggregated, privacy-preserving platform metrics). STS work warns that corporate “insights” may be ideologically framed and methodologically opaque.

Treat platform and payment policies as “field conditions,” not background noise. Digital safety research identifies platform precarity as a central threat shaping behavior and well-being.

Implications for IRBs and research governance

IRBs face a recurring dilemma: participant risks are real and high, but overly restrictive review can shift risk onto participants by blocking safer study designs or preventing community collaboration.

Concrete IRB-facing recommendations:

Adopt contextual internet research review rather than default “public content” assumptions; apply the SACHRP and AoIR frameworks as baseline.

Normalize high-confidentiality protocols for pornography worker studies (minimal identifiers, separation of contact data from responses, encrypted storage, careful reporting rules for quotations, and de-identification strategies tailored to small communities). The threat environment for creators includes doxxing and outing; confidentiality failures can be catastrophic.

Use Certificates of Confidentiality when eligible (and ensure consent forms include accurate CoC language and limits).

Avoid automatic “vulnerability” assumptions that erase agency. Ethics scholarship on sex work and payment argues for treating participants as agents and for compensating fairly while mitigating coercion through transparency and flexible participation.

Policy implications

Policy debates frequently draw on demand-side evidence (harm to youth, aggression, addiction). A supply-side lens suggests many worker harms arise from regulatory non-enforcement, platform/payment exclusion, and stigma-mediated governance, implying that consumer-restrictive policy alone is poorly targeted if the aim is harm reduction for workers.

Public health incident reporting also supports layered prevention approaches in production (beyond testing-only models), which can inform labor-oriented policy and workplace standards.

Open questions and feasible study designs

Unresolved questions that sustain the demand–supply gap

First, the field still lacks robust causal models of how platform curation and monetization translate demand into worker outcomes (income, safety practices, exposure to harassment), especially under conditions of shadowbanning, deplatforming, and payment instability.

Second, “harm” is often defined asymmetrically: consumer harms are treated as public outcomes, while worker harms are treated as occupational side effects. The epistemic injustice literature suggests this is partly an institutional credibility problem, not only a data-availability problem.

Third, measurement remains a bottleneck. Even within demand-side PPU work, instrument quality is not yet sufficient across domains; on the supply side, there are even fewer standardized measures for platform precarity, content leakage consequences, and workplace safety capacity in platform-mediated porn labor.

Five feasible study designs to address gaps

The designs below prioritize feasibility (including in jurisdictions where pornography is legal), emphasize ethical safeguards, and anticipate likely IRB concerns.

Study design	Gap addressed	Sample	Methods	Ethical safeguards (concrete)
Likely IRB concerns				
Participatory longitudinal cohort of adult content creators of deplatforming/payment disruptions	Worker outcomes over time; effects of deplatforming/payment disruptions	300–800 creators recruited via creator/sex worker organizations and snowballing	Baseline + quarterly surveys for 18–24 months; optional qualitative interviews with subsample	Community advisory board; minimal identifiers; separate contact database; “no screenshots/no handles” rule; encrypted storage; option to skip questions; crisis/harassment resources
Matched consumer–creator “ethical consumption” experiment + creator outcomes	Links demand interventions to worker economic/safety endpoints	Consumers (n≈1,000) + creators (n≈200)	Consumers randomized to different “labor transparency” labels; measure willingness-to-pay and viewing choices; creators pilot labeling and report changes in harassment/sales	Identifiability and outing risk; data security; retention contact procedures; payment ethics; recruitment via social platforms
Secure qualitative study of OHS and consent practices across production models	Supply-side heterogeneity: studio vs platform-mediated vs peer-to-peer	60–90 performers/creators across production types	Semi-structured interviews; analysis aligned with OHS and consent frameworks; compare hazard controls and reporting pathways	Trauma-informed interviewing; de-identified transcripts; careful paraphrase for unique stories; participant review of quotes; referral resources
Data linkage study using anonymized testing and “production hold” records with worker input	Evidence on effectiveness/limits of testing regimes and layered prevention	De-identified records from industry testing programs plus worker surveys	Data use agreement + statistical modeling; triangulate with worker-reported behaviors and prevention access	Strong de-identification; governance by worker-inclusive oversight group; publish only aggregate outcomes; no re-identification attempts
Platform governance audit + creator diary study under policy shifts	Mechanisms of deplatforming and censorship; causal timing	50–100 creators + systematic collection of platform policy updates	Mixed methods: weekly diaries capturing moderation events; parallel policy archive and automated capture of visibility metrics (non-identifying)	Do not collect account handles; participants log events locally then submit coded summaries; safe communication channels; operational security plan
			Researcher/participant security; platform interference; data validity without identifiers; risk of retaliation if platforms inferred	

These designs reflect the ethical guidance emphasizing contextual decision-making in internet research and sex-work-related scholarship urging collaboration and harm minimization.

